

RETIRING to Reboot

Corporate leaders leverage their passion and experience into a second innings, starting brave new ventures when most would be preparing for the golden years



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| By Nandini Vaish |

Exactly a year ago, Jagdish Khattar came up with an audacious thought. He would retire from Maruti Suzuki and set up his own venture, a chain of multi-brand auto sales and service outlets. The industry looked at him with disbelief. Why would a man at the helm of the country's largest automobile company want to leave a cushy job and start his own company—that too in his 60s?

His detractors, who included officials from the company, tried to talk him out of it. "The unorganised auto service industry is too large, and their costs too low. How will you compete?" they said. Servicing and repairing vehicles also meant that he would be competing directly with car dealers and service centres, many of whom he had been dealing with for years.

But Khattar, 67, had a bit of a

contrarian trait. He decided not to play golf, despite being a member of several golf courses, or "sit home and play with the grandchildren". Instead, he started his second innings as an entrepreneur and set up Carnation Auto. Today, he has 13 functional outlets in nine cities which clock in a monthly turnover of Rs 3 crore, and plans to scale up to nearly 30 outlets by March. He has also tied up with Dilip Chhabria for vehicle redesign and has launched the Workshop-on-Wheels service, a fleet of fully equipped vans that provide door-to-door car service. And people have taken note. "Today people in the 40s and 50s walk up to me and say that they too are looking at becoming entrepreneurs," says Khattar, even as he keeps getting calls from dealers to work with him.

Indeed. Silver start-ups seem to be picking up in India Inc. In 2004, Davinder Singh Brar, former CEO and managing director of Ranbaxy, joined GVK

“I don't like targets. It shows you can't do more. Business is not about what others think of you, but what the customer wants.”

JAGDISH KHATTAR, 67
TRANSITION: From MD, Maruti Suzuki to founder, Carnation Auto

BIG IDEA: Multi-brand service outlet for cars. The auto service industry is worth Rs 2,500 crore; much of it unorganised. That's opportunity.
CHALLENGE: Sourcing genuine parts from car companies as it clashes with dealer interest.